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Al Grey

Al Grey's trombone sound is immediately recognizable in the world of jazz. Born in 1925, he first played trombone in a Navy band. Early career highlights included work with Lionel Hampton, Benny Carter and Dizzy Gillespie. When a Basie trombone player became ill, Al stepped in and ended up playing with the orchestra from 1957-61 and 1964-77. His outstanding use of the plunger mute led to a Fred Astaire choreographed dance around one of his Basie solos. Al is a featured player at numerous festivals and jazz parties and directs Lionel Hampton's Golden Men of Jazz.

Al was interviewed in Scottsdale, Arizona on March 3, 1995 by Dr. Michael Woods.

MW: Okay these are some professionally taped video interviews with some of today's greatest jazz musicians. We're taping these interviews for Hamilton College to create an archive of jazz history and of oral culture and some of the recollections of our greatest musicians and what we consider cultural assets in this country. I'm interviewing Al Grey right now and we're just going to talk a little bit about some of the things that were effective in his life and some of his times with Count Basie and with Joe Williams. First of all, it's a real pleasure to have you, an honor.

AG: What a great interviewer. I'll have a moment to say hi out there to the jazz world.

MW: Yes. You told me of some of the places and people that you performed with before you met Count Basie. Start us there and bring us into your time with Count Basie.

AG: Well that'd be wonderful. I start back in the United States Navy. And as you know it was a long time before the blacks could enter the United States Navy, and when this came about I was still in school and I says well I know they're getting ready to draft me into the Army so before they draft me into the Army I will shoot for the Navy. So coming out of the of the Pottstown High School, in which I had played all the marches and played with the school dance band, but I played tuba, see. Because we didn't have any money and this is what the school had to offer, and they said the opportunity is to play the tuba. And so this was not the B flat tuba, the E flat tuba, which is different fingering from the regular bass clef instrument. And so I go out to Great Lakes, Illinois, where they had all these great musicians from all the great famous bands. And that was like musicians from Basie, Cab Calloway, Ellington, Les Brown, Jimmie Lunceford, and all these musicians was out there. So many musicians that they had to send musicians off to the various different camps, you know? And I entered into boot camp but I wanted to play music so I joined a bugle and drum corps. So I played the bugle. And in the morning I'd get up and play the colors, and learned all those different calls, but the glory and happiness of that

was that when the Great Lakes football team would play, you'd have that privilege of going to the games with the bugle and drum corps, see? And that was a treat because that's where they had Otto and Martin Graham and all those great football players that had come out of the various different schools. And from there I would try to play trombone because the tuba had become obsolete, where the tuba had went out. There was no more tuba playing in which it's coming back today again. It's that cycle going around.

MW: About what year would this have been when you changed over from the trombone to the tuba?

AG: No, from the tuba —

MW: From the tuba to the trombone?

AG: Yes, from the tuba to the trombone, was in 19 — I went into the Navy in 1942, so this was like 1939. And so I wanted to play in the band because they had all these great musicians: Clark Terry and Osie Johnson and Dudley Brooks and all these famous musicians, but they wouldn't let me in because they were using the string bass now. And so I would get up and go into the head in the morning and start practicing on the trombone because it was a bass clef instrument, and finally, one of the guys went over the hill one day, which was Rocks McConnell, who was one of the all-time great trombone players at that time, and he wrote a tune called "Sweet Slumber," which he played with Lucky Millender's great orchestra, and this tune had become a hit, and here he was in the service, and a big check came to him and he went over the hill, and I have never seen him since — none of us — he just disappeared. So here Al Grey comes along to sit in for him for inspection, where they come through and inspect all your clothes etcetera, and the band, and I would sit in his chair to cover for him, which we hoped that he would come back. And from this, this is where I got teaching from many of the great artists that was in the band, and they then sent me out to New England, out there in Hingham, Massachusetts, which was an ammunition depot, where they had so many people in the Navy that could not read or write at that time. And I used to even write letters home to some of the kids' parents and everything like that. Because when they would go get paid they would make this X. See now you're not going to hear none of this kind of talk today, because it's not like that anymore. But at that time it was. And we had the freedom of going out anywhere we wished, as a musician, see? Because all we did was play music. Now they did all of this stevedore work in the igloos and things where they had smokeless powder and all like this, but we played in the band. And what happened to me is that I would go into Boston, and go jamming with Sabby Lewis, who had a famous band, and this is where I learned more about playing jazz, because he had a great, great group. Beverly White who still plays today with Bobby Short, and Sabby Lewis. And from there I began to learn and they began to call me the "Sailor Boy" because I started

getting pretty good with the trombone. But then the sailors that we had in Hingham from being not able to read or write and like that, they were contained like in the department where they didn't have no — to go out on liberty as it was called. See they had to stay there and so they got jealous of the band. See they can go out and everything, and would you believe they changed it around and wanted the band to go out there and do this work. And here the saxophone players with the fingers and everything, so we complained to the point writing a letter to the president and everything, telling them here we are, third class, second class and first class petty officers with our lyre up here for playing music, and here you've got us, we want to go out. And they said well they know too much, see? And they shipped our band out to Grosse Hill Naval Air Station in Detroit, outside of Detroit, Michigan. And from there I got out of the Navy. Benny Carter's band came through town to play at the Paradise Theater which was the famous theater of Detroit at that time, which still, I think they've renovated it again. The Paradise Theater. And I went by to see Benny Carter, and they said, "Oh, we need a trombone player and I've been hearing about you around here playing at all the different clubs."

MW: So you were in the right place at the right time.

AG: Right place at the right time, and I took J.J. Johnson's place in Benny Carter's orchestra, see? And I went out with Benny Carter and this was 1945, see? And then after that, Benny Carter had such a great band where Benny Carter was a person that was tremendous help in teaching more how to read, and play ad lib solos see? Because back in those days most of our jazz musicians were great jazz artists, but many of them could not read.

MW: So they had to do much of it by ear?

AG: That's the way it was. Just like Louis Armstrong, see? This is where Louis Armstrong — and from this finally, again coming from Pottstown, where there was only like five or six black families, I had that opportunity to go to the white school in Pottstown. And like I was like the only black kid in the junior high school band but we had Kenny Hines, another black kid, in the band in high school. And so this gave a privilege of learning how to read.

MW: So you were able to read notes at that time.

AG: Yes, see, so this has like been my history throughout life, this is how I was able to get in the band from reading. And so this is when Benny Carter accepted me, but then Benny Carter, after a year after that, he broke up his band to go into the studios out in Hollywood, to write for movies and he became very famous with "Peyton Place," and see, which back in those times no one ever knew it because they didn't give you credit for that at that time, see? It was a long time before Benny Carter was credited for these things. But Jimmie must have heard that Benny Carter was breaking up his band, and so

Jimmie Lunceford came to see the Benny Carter band the last two nights that it was going to be together and Jimmie Lunceford selected me, and Joe Wilder and Renauld Jones. And we all joined Jimmie Lunceford's band.

MW: And then, tell us how you got to work with Basie.

AG: Oh, to get to work with Basie was much longer after that. From Jimmie Lunceford, I went with Lucky Millinder's orchestra, who had Lil Green and many — Bull Moose Jackson and all of these great artists. And from Lucky Millinder, this is when I left Lucky Millinder and went with Lionel Hampton, see? And I played with Lionel Hampton five years, which again was breaking ground into becoming a name out there, but then after leaving Lionel Hampton, in which Lionel Hampton was a band that you played over time a very, very much, a lot. And one night he played way overtime too long and I just got up and left. And then instead of the rest of the band staying put, three of the other guys, trombone players left, and when Lionel Hampton turned around to go into the slide for "Flying Home," [humms] there wasn't no trombone players there. So Lionel's wife came out and said I was a bad influence on the band, and you are fired, you are fired. And it was the greatest thing that really could happen to me at that time because this was in Cleveland, Ohio, and I went into New York the very next day and they had a place where all the jazz musicians used to hang around in New York, Beefsteak Charlie's and Juniors, and this was where all the musicians around would come to try to get a job. So now I needed a job, see? And would you believe I ran into Sy Oliver and he had the band at that time at the Empire State Building, and he was doing lots of recording at that time. So he signed me on to play in the studio band the first black trombone player. They had at that time they had Taft Jordan and Billy Kyle, the piano player that went on with Louis Armstrong. And so this gave me a job where I was making three times more money and was staying right in New York and didn't have to go no up and down the road, because again, there were some hard days of traveling.

MW: Share with us just a moment, what it was like traveling from city to city at that time. Give us a year, some of the years of your travel, like let's say '47 or '55 or whatever, and tell us what it was like for traveling musicians at that time.

AG: It was very bad because we could not eat right because we couldn't go into restaurants and have a meal, we'd have to go around the back. And we couldn't go into none of the hotels, we'd have to try to find a room at maybe a school teacher's home that had a nice decent home, or a doctor's home, or a lawyer's home, because they were the ones that might have a place, an extra room. So we would get off the bus and scour around that town to see where we could get a room and that's the way it was. And you did nothing but one nighters, see? But then Benny Carter, we did many engagements for the Army

which we signed away our lives to ride on the C-27 planes, and but then things began, we could see where things began to get better.

MW: About what year was this, when you felt things began to get better?

AG: This is coming into like 1948. And see then, every now and then up north you could stay in a white hotel. See but it wasn't still that much, although I have to put in a little thing here. We had a trombone player that played with Lionel Hampton, and he was Japanese, Paul Higaki, and it was worse for him. So it made us feel that we can go on and make it, see, because like his parents was prisoners down in Denver in the prison camp after the war, and Lionel Hampton took him on and he could play trombone really well. And then leaving all of this, going to Lionel, then going to Lucky Millinder, I went with Dizzy Gillespie. And we still had those bad times. And we had really rough times with Lucky Millinder because we played in the south mostly. See this was the days where we used to play tobacco warehouses and things. And this is where the blacks would have to sit up in the balcony and we would play to the whites. And I remember we finally got to San Antonio, Texas one time, and the people, they had the chairs to separate the back to back, the blacks was over here and the whites was over here. But the whites didn't — seems like they loved the music so they just started moving the chairs and so they started mingling and this is where we could see changes being made.

MW: So the music made the difference.

AG: Yeah. I would dare so very strongly about that. Why because coming up with Dizzy doing things for the State Department and everything like that, we could begin to see these things. But coming on up into Basie, in which you know I spent almost 20 years of my life off and on with Basie, that's a pretty long stint there, okay? And how I came into Count Basie's band was that Dizzy Gillespie was going to break up his band because transportation became very big and now it was changing over to flying. And so Dizzy was bringing his big band back down to small combinations, see? But we had such a tremendous band that every one of those guys who came out of there are stars today, the ones that are left and all like that, and that was like Lee Morgan, Wynton Kelly, and Phil Woods and Melba Liston and Billy Mitchell, who I brought into Count Basie's band see because Lockjaw left. And I got this job by going by Pep's Show Bar in Philadelphia, Pennsylvania, where Basie came in to play, and I went by to see Basie's band, and would you believe, one of his trombone players was sick that night. And this is in the days when Count Basie only used three trombones, and here there's only two trombones. And Count Basie didn't even know my name, but the musicians knew me. And they started pointing out into the audience, "There's Al Grey down there in the audience down there," and they said, "maybe he can sit in." And this is South Philadelphia, I lived in North Philadelphia,

man I broke out of there and went to North Philadelphia and came back and I played so much that night that Basie said, "what are you doing?" "Nothing."

MW: So you ran and got your horn.

AG: Yeah. I went to the north side. We lived up on North Philadelphia near the ballpark up there near the stadium on North 27th Street. I got my horn and came back and, coming from Dizzy, you know I was playing pretty strong by then, you know? So yeah, I sitted in and played music and played solos that was really outasight. And so Count Basie called me back to his dressing room and said, "well we're getting ready to go to England in the next five days, and we'd like to take you along with us, could you make it?" I says, "I don't have a passport, but I'll fix a way to get one." And so that very next morning I went all the way to Washington, DC, and got myself a passport, came back and went to New York and played my first recording with Count Basie, where it was a change in Count Basie's band. And this is when Snooky Young came back to the band and Lockjaw Davis and I. And this is when we really changed that band all around. See because before that Basie had his band, you know and everything, but here we are now where Joe Williams was getting ready to leave pretty soon after that—

MW: I want you to finish your story about the Basie band when you joined that, and then we're going to come back and tell a little bit about Joe.

AG: Yeah, see but see well this is all the working at this time, which, I spent a lot of time during that time, this is where it starts with 19-1/2 years you see.

MW: Now what was that first year you started with Basie?

AG: 57. 1957. And so I go into the band, went to Washington DC, came back, went to New York for a recording. And this is the first recordings that Neal Hefti brought to the band. And this is when we recorded, I got my first solo in the band, "Little Tempo Please" and then after a couple of days, we went to England. And we went to England to play for the Queen, which is where we played a Royal Command Performance for the Queen of England. Yeah, that's it, that is the one. This is when I joined the band, and this man right here, Neal Hefti wrote "Little Tempo Please" for me. And from coming from Dizzy Gillespie's band, see I was manipulating very well with the Stride see, so this is why —so this sort of helped to update Basie's band. And Snooky Young, where he was hitting those notes sky high, and then later on went with "The Tonight Show" for 27 years, and then Lockjaw Davis. And we really turned the band around so that they started buying Count Basie's orchestra. See because you must look at the fact that all orchestras, it seems to me that they have to have a singer. So you look at the history, you see where if you don't have that main singer, like Count Basie, his band went down after he lost Jimmy Rushing. And then Helen Humes comes along and started building up. But after that, it went a long time until he had to break his band down to a small band, which was

the Kansas City Seven, see, which I had chances and all like that to play later on for a movie with the Kansas City Seven with Count Basie for a film made in Paris with Ann Margaret. But all before that, we had many nights that it wouldn't be that many people in the place because they were automatically looking for that singer. And if you don't have that singer, that means something different then. And now coming along, but we had such great soloists, that the band could make it by this change, with "Whirly Bird" with Lockjaw Davis and with Snooky Young and Joe Newman see, and Frank Wess and Marshall Royal, Sonny Payne. Well these guys, you must also remember that when I joined the band, Count Basie's personnel had been the same for like 12, 14 years, same personnel. So when I joined the band, I didn't have no name at all. I was called the "new boy" and I didn't used to like that. And that was on me for a whole year, until the next person came into the band, and this is when I got my name. But then, when I did get my name, I had become so prominent with that band until Basie said, "oh, this is the fabulous one — Fab." And that is my name today, they call me "Fab" but that comes from Count Basie who started calling me fabulous because I could go out and get standing ovations every night, every night. Standing ovations, until this became a big part of Count Basie's band, until when we'd go out where we'd have Frank Sinatra and Ella Fitzgerald, that meant that Count Basie's band didn't have no chance to play, but opening number, a middle number, and like the featured drum number, and then they would bring Ella on and then Frank. This is where it was always sad moments, too, because here you have all these great musicians sitting there playing the music for the singers, you see? And they know that they're good, and had no opportunity to express themselves. And I know many won't even take a day or two to talk about this but I've gone far enough in life that I feel as though I do have that privilege to speak about that because in a sense in music that would be a no-no, all these different things that come on with bands. I myself, after joining, we recorded that day and then a few days later we go to England, and here this is still the days where they didn't have that many baths in the hotels, but we still stayed like in the Queens hotels and things. And we could really completely tell the difference of the treatment.

MW: In other words, you were treated differently in Europe?

AG: Completely different. You was treated like an artist. Like artists are supposed to be treated. And they would roll out the royal carpet to you and you was treated that way. And you was accepted that way. Well, I myself, leaving the United States, it was a long time in my belief, gee, how is it this much of a difference, you see? And again, a lot of this that I am speaking about, wasn't permissible a few years ago to even make statements. But here this is to the Hamilton College, and I would want the students and everything to know what you have come here to talk about, okay? But for myself, when I

first got over there, there was no music written out for me. And that just drove me crazy after playing solos at night after night and a lot of them with Dizzy Gillespie. Now I come in to Count Basie's band, and there's no music written for me.

MW: So he had to do much of the music by memory?

AG: Well on that particular tour, the musicians had been in the band so long they only took three books with them. And that was Snooky's book, Lockjaw's book, and my book. And they saved all this money for not taking all the rest of these books. It used to run into big costs, you know. And here I am buried in the music, now I want to solo so bad, 'cause Joe Newman just went out there and he just performed like ever. And here's Sonny Payne and Frank Wess and me and later I just -- and Henry Coker who was a trombone player, and Benny Powell. Now I get no chance to play, nothing, nothing.

MW: Let me ask you a question. Was there any etiquette by which you could kind of go to Basie and say, he, you know, I want you to throw me a solo here?

AG: Well, it boiled down to where I felt as though that coming from Dizzy I should get a few bars. So one day we were in line, this is when you had to jump off the bus and run in and get in line because you know that the bath is going to run out. So that means that you're going to have to go down the hall to get a bath, you see? So this particular day I jumped off and run in and I get in line and here I am, the new boy and everything, and everybody was always jumping in front of me because I was the new boy. So you're the new boy and you'd better recognize it and accept it if you're going to stay in that band. And so this day I was getting ready to sign in for this band, and Marshall Royal ran in and said "Royal" and, he was the Straw Boss, and they gave him this last bath. And I just went off in the lobby of this hotel. I just went to hollering and screaming and cussing and going on. And of course you know this is a no-no, you know you're not supposed to do like that in the Queen Hotel, and because I was completely so uptight from not playing any solos. And you'd pick up the paper the next day and they're talking about Marshall and Snooky and all these guys that did all this last night, and you don't see your name or anything like that because you hadn't did anything, see? And so he got this last bath and I just went off because I was so upset from not playing. But Count Basie was sitting in the corner over there. He would always wait until last because you know he had his suite coming and everything like that. And he finally got my attention and he beckoned me and he says, "come over here." And I says, well I said, "I was in line and I was correct to get my bath and he just stepped in front of me." And Basie said, "well he's Straw Boss, you know how they are." And he tried to calm me down. But I went in to saying, "well look, I don't know why you hired me because I come over here and you won't let me play anything." And this is when he came up and I had never heard him cuss or anything like that but he came up with a cuss word, and said, "one minute — you just got here. Now when we get

back to New York, we're going to fix up music and everything for you, but you just got here and so we can't do nothing about it and this is no jam band and so we're not going to have no jam session," and he says, "but you know, I like you, and I'll tell you what I'm going to do. I'm going to let you come down, have a bath in my room and there's an extra room over here, the suite, and you can stay there tonight." And this is when he, like he became like my father. Because then I would listen to everything he had to say.

MW: Tell us about that name, when you called him "Chief."

AG: Yeah, well, after that he became like my father, everybody called him "Chief." Not Count Basie or Count or nothing. It was Chief. And anybody, everyone in that band, it was "Chief," not Count Basie or Basie. But before I went into the band it was always "Count Basie" see. And so Basie then would say that you've got a place here. So we come back to New York, and they wrote up so much music for me until one day Basie had to come to me and say that I'm getting static from the other trombone players, and I'm going to have to take some of these numbers and put them in a shuffle here and pass them out to Henry Coker and Benny Powell, because they're not — he really took a liking to me and so I became his featured star, you understand? And then, it was Sonny Payne and then Joe Williams, okay? So from this he passed out these different tunes for solos, but it got to the place he still, that he did call these numbers. And so Henry Coker became upset about this, because he had been there, and so he decided to leave the band and he went with Ray Charles. And this was how it happened, see, because he wasn't getting enough to play. And then Benny Powell left and went with Merv Griffin show, you see, because they said that here I just come in and took over. What about this monster, you know? But it wasn't meant like that, it was just that we didn't get enough playing time. You've got to get some playing time if you want to be out in this business, see? And so if it's meant that you have to play for a show that's come on, play for Ella Fitzgerald, play for Frank Sinatra, there's no room to give everybody a solo. So but you do get a chance to do a solo when you play a dance. But then that's when you're not noticed that much, because they're there to dance and they are there to talk to their friends. And this is a completely different type of interview here, I must tell you that, but this is the way it was.

MW: Tell us one of the most fun or one of the craziest times that you had with the Basie band. A funny story that happened with the Basie band.

AG: Well you know Dizzy's band was a pretty wild band. We was pretty wild in Dizzy Gillespie's band. And now here I'm in a society band, you know I mean you set up everything, you didn't slouch or nothing in your chair or nothing, and you set up in Lunceford's band because everyone came out of the university where you know it's been taught, in Nashville, Tennessee. Can't think this minute. But anyway, we're playing for the Queen now, and I'm just getting in the band now, and I hadn't been in the band but a

week, and now we're playing for the Queen, and we're in line, here's the Count Basie's band, here's Mario Bauza, and over here is Judy Garland, and here standing alongside are The Rockettes. And here one of the Rockettes was kind of whispering, "where's the party tonight?" And now they're playing "America" [hums], and we're at attention here. But then when it was over, ready for his [inaudible] I says, "just meet me back stage and we'll talk about where the party will be." And, but, somebody heard this voice and automatically the new boy was blamed for this. It did not say anything, this was one of the Rockettes said this. And so Marshall and Charlie Fowlkes, they came off and they were furious, furious boy, and to the point of where I almost got in a fight right there with Charlie Fowlkes. And I kept on saying, "I didn't do nothing, I didn't say anything," I said, "it was somebody else who said that. And what broke it up was that Thad Jones. He said, "Well you up front there, you just can't see nothing back there and everything so why are you on this van here?" And it was Thad Jones that caused it to become peaceful. But it was laughed about a lot after. See I was going through all of this before, because I wasn't playing nothing at that time. See all of this was leading up to that day which I had told you about. But then we had a still, which the Basie band still has today, a kangaroo court.

MW: Okay, tell us about that.

AG: Which I cannot give completely in details, because that's just like one of the, still, of the secrets of the Basie organization. And they had a thing in this where you could be brought up on charges, you could be brought up on charges, and that meant that if you was held getting drunk that night or something or something that day you could be brought up on charges for, and it was where if you were guilty, you had to pay a fine. You had pay a $5 fine. Now this kitty grew so much that they had enough money in the funds to give out for the [inaudible]. Because Basie would be brought up on charges too, see? They call it the Bat Fund. And so that means that he's off tonight and you're in the street somewhere and you're out with a lady that didn't come up to what they used to classify, is she a bear or is she beautiful, or — and they would — and that's the way it was. And then he could come up with it was kind of touchy, they don't know whether it was quite enough or whether to go on the other side, like was she ugly or — and so another thing, you'll never hear this because this was completely secret of that band. But I finally got out of the club. We were playing down at the Deauville Hotel on the beach in Miami, Florida and this night, it was two elderly ladies, one was in her seventies and the other lady was in her eighties. Now I brought these two ladies to meet Count Basie because they had been going to see Count Basie in their younger life. And this hotel was a hotel where they used to have a lot of people that retired and they stayed there. Now they wanted to come and say hello to Mr. Basie, and let him know that they loved his

music for many, many years. Well, this fund was a no-no. I had no business to be taking these elderly ladies, so they brought me up to court and I was charged $10, because now I had two, you see, and I'm charged $10 for these two elderly ladies, which I had no business being there, see, so as far as the kangaroo court was concerned. So this is when I resigned. Because I said to Basie, I said, "Chief you know, you know darn well that there's nothing going on or anything here, they wanted to meet you and I brought them here." And they said "well he brought them there where Count Basie could get the fine so we feel as though we should put the fine on you." Because now Basie would say come in and relax and have a glass of water or something there. He would have been liable for that. See we had lawyers and all like this see in the kangaroo court. In fact I was one of the lawyers. And the judge is still with the Count Basie band today. Bill Hughes, he's the judge. And Mario Bauza is still the Treasurer, who collects this money. So this is still, but they have indicated that if someone was sick that was in the band, they would take money out of this fund, because this was — and this was a lot of stuff. And the gentleman who we're going to talk about a little later on, same difference, because he did one thing one time —

MW: We want you to tell us about one thing ... tell us about Joe Williams.

AG: Now in this court, I was the new boy and I've just joined the band. So this day that they had Joe Williams on the carpet, I talked to Joe Williams the other day by the way for a half hour, he's well and everything, and we had some fun talking about many years ago. And why, because Joe Williams, I used to play all the fills for Joe Williams, when Joe would sing. And when I first started doing it I used to have problems doing it. Many years ago when I was with Lionel Hampton they had a blues singer, Sonny Parker, and he would start singing the blues and he would get stuck for words and there would be such a big gap in between until I started filling in these gaps. And so Lionel Hampton said, "well leave it in, Gates." And so that's where I like started. And so through history I come along and I started playing fills for Ella Fitzgerald and Bing Crosby and for Sarah Vaughan. And see now I come in to Count Basie's orchestra, and I started playing the part of making these fills for Joe. But sometimes Joe would sing lyrics and I would cover him up. And so one night Joe didn't like it at all, you know. "You know you done covered up my lyrics, Fab," I can hear him saying it now. And so Basie called the two of us aside. He said "here's what I want you to do. Anytime Joe sings, just stay out of his way. Now if you find a crack to get in there, get in there, see, but otherwise, stay out of Joe's way." And that's when I learned that when Basie, he was like a coach. And he used to tell me, see because when we made a recording, "Going to Chicago and sorry I can't take you" and this is where I would make this fills [humms]. It's like somebody who's getting ready to have all kinds of affairs going on so this is where I could get in there. But

if you covered the lyrics, which I really did find out it was very bad. And so that was one of my first lessons. But this now I'm with the band about six days, now they have Joe Williams on the carpet for something that came up. Now they didn't let me into this meeting, because like I was too new. And I wondered and wondered and wondered, what was going on in this meeting that day. And then finally the case was pretty bad, and Joe Williams lost that case, and the punishment was that he had a very long thing of "Every Day" before Joe would come on [humms] and then we'd play like a verse before Joe would come on. And so Count Basie, the punishment was don't announce his name. And so Joe would have to come out to the mic with no announcement, and going into "Every Day." And that's the truth. So I know he will be seeing all of this and he might not like it, but, I told him I was going to talk about it. And so whatever it was, this was supposed to be a week that it was going to be. But after the third day, Joe apologized for whatever this was. And then Count Basie the next day started calling his name in the introduction, Joe Williams. And the other times, by playing all these fills all the time, it became a very big part there for playing all these different blues, so big until Fred Astaire came to see the band one night. And he thought I played so much plunger in between the lyrics of Joe Williams, that he did a choreography of what I played on the plunger. And it became an Emmy for Fred Astaire and Barrie Chase. And we went out to the studio to do this, in Hollywood, and we had recorded this number at the Universal Studios in Chicago. And it was early in the morning, after we had got off from the Blue Note, in Chicago, and we recorded like three o'clock until five o'clock in the morning, and this is when Joe Williams came up with that tune "Five O'Clock in the Morning," that's when that came up. Well anyway, Fred Astaire had made a choreography of what I played. So you know about three or four o'clock in the morning, and that's the days when yeah, we used to drink a lot. And that's the day when they had a lot of moonshine, see? And so I was feeling pretty good, feeling real wonderful, and I played these fills, and I played so much and it came off so great. Now here Fred Astaire and we are in the studios, and at that time, they couldn't figure out what I was doing with the plunger. They could write notes down, but —

MW: They couldn't notate the use of the color on the plunger?

AG: That's the reason I have a book out now, a method of the plunger for trumpets and trombones. That's the reason I have this. Because now I get in the studio and I can't play what they have written down here for me. And here all this money is going out the window. And I'm looking at Fred Astaire, we'll go a few bars and they had to cut because I had messed up, because I wasn't getting exactly what was the way it was designed for him to do for he and Barrie Chase. And he'd go down on his knees and wheel around and now this is when he was beginning to get older, see and I'm looking at

this until I finally said, and then Count Basie, he never comes out of the booth, now he comes around to me and he says, "what's wrong, Fab?" And I say, "oh, Chief," I said, "I can't read this because the positions that I played with my plunger on that date I can't get with, and it's not written like I played it, and so I don't know what to do." And they were getting very worried, because here we had went into the studio like 8:00 that morning and here it is going on 11:30 and we hadn't accomplished the first number. Now I had gotten upset and nervous and everything, and then I finally said — and you know I had a J&B's last night, I mean when we did this recording, and everything, and I said you know, and here I'm out here and haven't had nothing, and now Marshall Royal is laughing at me, because he's saying that, "oh, we're going to make a whole lot of money today because the time is running on." And then to see Fred Astaire doing like he was there, and I'm not getting his steps in right with the plunger. That became, oh, I was so embarrassed, I was so ashamed of myself, and here the engineers and everybody's making all this money and here Al Grey is messing it up, and was messing it up. Until finally they said, "well I'll tell you what, we're going to take off right now, and the band can go to lunch." Now they're supposed to get off at 12:00, but they cut right there, because Fred Astaire was getting pretty tired. So what happened, I said, "well let me hear the record." And I got a piece of paper, and went in the studio, while they went out and had their lunch and everything, because, now I had become a nervous wreck. It really, in fact, that's the worst thing in my history to this day, to ever happen to me in this business. Still the worst thing that ever happened. So now they're out for lunch, now they got from 11:30 until 1:00, they got to have an extra half hour. And so now I'm so worried and everything, and I got a paper and started listening to this record, what I played, and I was working, and ... oh you did that, oh you did this, you closed it up here, and I started making these markings. So this is where I come up with my book. We went back and they sent out and got this bottle of booze for me, and the first one I was so nervous because I was just shaking, it's true, you know? And so I said "give me a triple." And I downed it and boom, I downed it and I looked over my notes again, and, thank God, the very first take we went back and it just came off just like that. And what a — and so I says, "Marsh" we called him, Marshall Royal, "you're not going to make no more money off of me today." And then they went on with the rest of the things that Joe had to do that day, and it came up for an Emmy and I received a gold watch from Fred Astaire.

MW: You know that is another thought process that I want to pursue just on the side some more. And that is, even though they were trying to work from a solo that you had already played, when they went back and put it into literate culture, and put it on paper, it was hard for you to create it, re-create it. Am I correct?

AG: Correct. Why? Because they didn't write it like I played it, you see. See they did not write it like, and anyone in school that's studying music today, remember that.

MW: Okay, now we're coming just to the end of our hour-long tape that we have here. I'd like to ask you just one more question just for right now at any rate. And that is, if you had something that you wanted to say to students of music, and to the field of music as a whole, or to jazz more specifically, from your years of experience. Tell us some of the things that you think are important about the idiom and tell us in your own words how you feel oral culture is a part of jazz.

AG: Jazz, well, you see you must look at it like this. They started having jazz artists to come in the schools and it hasn't been that many years ago. And so they would bring Frank Foster and Basie's band, we would come out and start doing clinics before concerts sometimes in schools, because we played many universities and colleges. So then Basie would pick me and Marshall for the saxes and Joe Newman for the trumpet, and we discovered that you get it in the books, you read it in the books, but to get the feeling of it, that's not taught. You have to get that yourself. And so your teachers, they can't teach that to you. So it's very valuable to have someone to come in to class and even just show you how to breathe. Because I find that's one of my biggest problems a lot of times with a trombone player, he's blowing and he's blowing, but there's no one to tell Louis Armstrong how to blow his horn. And when he passed on, he had a big gash in his lip, a big gash, almost a quarter of an inch deep, where he kept pushing it in. So when I went to New England Conservatory of Music and had some lessons from John Coffey of the Boston Symphony, while I was in the Navy up there, I would get these lessons, you see? And he taught you to put all of this into your diaphragm and do it from the lip. Now also, what made Count Basie so great was he knew how to play, where we played "Little Darlin'" so soft. They don't have the time to teach you about dynamics that much. Although you have pf or double p or f, double f or three f, you see? And they mark it on the paper, but if you have no experience of doing this, you're going to have to play on the same level. So Basie could say "whisper here" and all of a sudden we had this "All of Me" [humms]. And out of that, anybody talking, you just jumped out of your seat just from that one bar [humms]. All the way back down to complete, and that's not easy, you have to learn about those things. So anyone you see, and then you see if you're supposed to be playing in this section and then you're supposed to get louder and you're supposed to come back, you start completely playing attention to your dynamics.

MW: And at that we're going to have to stop for right now. This has been Al Grey, and this has been an interview for Hamilton College, an interview with a great jazz artist.

PART II

MW: We are here with Al Grey and we are very flattered to have such a fabulous musician to help us here with our Hamilton College Archive that we're developing. We interviewed him once before, but he has some marvelous things to share with us. Thank you for playing that little piece for us on the trombone. Play another little one for us. Just a couple of little licks.

AG: Here's one that we played all the time in the quintet.
[Al plays "April in Paris"]

MW: All right.

AG: We used to have to play this sometimes maybe three times a night, it was so asked for, the most requested tune that we had in the book, "April in Paris." And all the students at Hamilton, I appreciate to have a few minutes to talk with you out there, and I want to let you know that this is a happy heart of finding out in the world that if you have a will, you can make it out there. And so Count Basie was that will that gave me all kinds of inspiration to be a pretty good artist today, and to do all the fills and things, many-a-times for Joe Williams, we have beautiful hearts, and I loved that band and everyone in that band, and so I have a lot to say today that if you have a will of wanting to play, I want you to get out there and come in with my idol, and he used to say "practice, practice, practice." And I thank you for letting me have a moment with you. And you have been mighty wonderful, Mike, I thank you so much.

MW: Well you know we really try and, it's an honor, the whole purpose of doing these interviews was to let some of the students that are coming along that would not have seen some of these great bands personally, get to see what some of these great artists have to say. And there is something about an oral history, about just letting you talk and be yourself on camera, that brings an aliveness to it, that a textbook doesn't do.

AG: That's so true. And thank you again, and I'm getting ready to do a set. Thank you.